

US:CENTRAL STATES

FAMOUS FOR COWBOYS AND CATTLE RANCHES, the central states of the US are also the country's "bread basket" and oil refinery. This vast region includes high mountains, fertile plains, and the Mississippi River system. Texas and Oklahoma have major oil and gas fields, while coal is mined in Wyoming and Montana. The Rocky Mountains contain important national parks, such as Yellowstone and Glacier, and are rich in mineral resources. Hot summers and cold winters, as well as violent hailstorms and tornadoes, make the region's climate one of extremes.

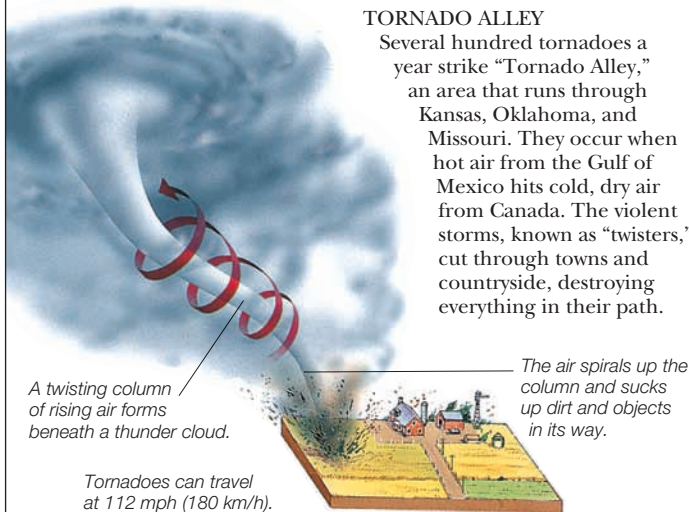


THE GREAT PLAINS

Once home to millions of buffalo, the vast open plains between the Rocky Mountains and the Mississippi River are now planted with cereal grains. Farmers on the Great Plains produce more wheat and corn than anywhere else on Earth. Farming is highly mechanized, with huge machines to harvest the grain. In drier parts, the land can be farmed only if it is irrigated, often using water taken from a natural underground reservoir, called an aquifer.

TORNADO ALLEY

Several hundred tornadoes a year strike "Tornado Alley," an area that runs through Kansas, Oklahoma, and Missouri. They occur when hot air from the Gulf of Mexico hits cold, dry air from Canada. The violent storms, known as "twisters," cut through towns and countryside, destroying everything in their path.



RURAL AMERICA

Today, most Americans live in cities and towns, but at the start of the 20th century, two out of every five adults lived on farms. There are still many small towns with populations of less than 10,000 people. These towns are often in farming country and are where people go for supplies, to attend school, church, or special events, such as this fair.

Hats keep off the sun and the rain, and were once used to carry water.

Leather cuffs

Chaps protect the rider from cattle horns.

Fringe helps to drain away any rainwater.

COWBOY COUNTRY

Cattle are raised on the Great Plains and foothills of the Rocky Mountains. In summer, cowboys on horseback used to drive the cattle to fresh pastures; in winter, they herded them back to the ranch to be sold at auction for food. Hollywood movies turned cowboys into heroes, but life in the saddle was not easy. Pay was poor, and men often spent 15 hours a day on horseback in scorching heat or driving rain. Today, ranches are smaller and cowboys and horses may be ferried from ranch to pasture by truck and trailer.

A lasso is used to rope cattle.

Boots have heels to keep feet firmly in the stirrups.

CITIES OF THE DEAD

Cemeteries in New Orleans are built above ground to protect them when the Mississippi floods. The burial grounds are called Cities of the Dead.

A wreath of flowers



MISSISSIPPI RIVER

From Minnesota in the north to its enormous delta in the Gulf of Mexico, the mighty Mississippi River flows through the central states. It is one of the world's busiest waterways, suitable for cargo boats for almost 1,802 miles (2,900 km). This view of the river shows it flowing through Iowa, where it forms a natural border with Illinois and Wisconsin. In the south, severe flooding often occurs after heavy rains.